UNIT 3: EXPLORING CAREERS

TOPIC 5: INTERNSHIPS

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand what an internship is
- Understand how to handle some common internship challenges
- Understand that self-reflection and journal writing can help to enhance an internship experience

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Identify solutions to potential internship challenges
- Select and/or create journal questions that would help them reflect most effectively on an internship experience

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Brainstorm

Objective: Students will understand what an internship is.
Time: 10 minutes
Materials: Flipchart paper, markers, handout: "What is an Internship?"

Ask students to call out what they think an internship is. Write all of their ideas on the flipchart paper. Work with the students to create a definition from their ideas. Ask students what makes an internship different from a job.

Hand out "What is an Internship?" Ask students to pick out the important points from the two definitions. Discuss the reasons why people participate in internships and the value of internship experience.

Common reasons that people intern:

- To develop professional skills and gain hands-on experience in their field of interest
- To apply their academic coursework to a real-world work situation
- To explore career options and develop their personal sense of vocation
- To learn how organizations operate
- To begin building their professional network
- To gain exposure to careers and jobs
- To build occupational knowledge and technical skills

Adapted from http://www.nww.org/qwbl/tools/kcktoolkit/Print_Toolkit.PDF and
http://www.stolaf.edu/services/cel/students/Internships_Getting_Started.html

Small Group Activity

Objectives:
- Students will identify solutions to potential internship challenges.
- Students will understand how to handle some common internship challenges.

Time: 30 minutes

Materials: Pens/pencils, paper

Divide students into groups of 3-4. Have them create four potentially challenging scenarios that an intern might face and write them out neatly on one piece of paper. Once all of the groups have created their scenarios, instruct each group to pass their scenarios to the group to their right (or however you want them to pass the scenarios).

Explain to the groups that they will have about 10 minutes to discuss the scenarios and work together to figure out how they could best handle each situation. Groups will then either present the scenarios as well as their suggested best way to handle each situation OR choose 2 of the scenarios to act out for the larger group.

Once the scenarios have been presented and/or acted out, the larger group should discuss the different situations and suggest other professional ways to handle the challenge. Four common internship problems are listed below. If these challenges are not presented to the group, you should introduce the challenges to the group and ask for possible solutions. Offer the possible solutions below as other options, if they are not mentioned.

Possible Problem	Possible Solution
The internship doesn't meet your expectations.	1) List out and assess your expectations. Are they realistic? If so, think about ways to meet them and consider talking to your internship supervisor about them. If you decide they're not realistic, try to figure out why. 2) If you started the internship with a specific position description, reference that description to see if it accurately represents the work you're doing. 3) If you don't already have one, consider working with your supervisor to create a learning contract. This is a good way to chart out internship expectations for both you and the organization. If you already have a learning contract, review it and modify if possible.
You and your internship supervisor have conflicting goals or priorities.	Some degree of difference is natural. If your differences are extreme, talk to your supervisor openly and positively to see if you can find a middle ground. Remember that your supervisor should want you to have a positive, useful experience. Try to meet your supervisor's expectations while also meeting your own.
Boredom	Ask for new projects. If you notice a need or an area that could use some work, offer to work on it. If you show initiative and help solve problems, you'll stand out and gain even better experience for your future.
Poor communication	Many workplace problems are a result of poor communication. Don't hesitate to talk to your supervisor about your concerns, but be sure to do so in a diplomatic, positive, and professional way. Most supervisors do not take on an intern unless they're committed to providing a positive experience.

From http://www.clacareer.umn.edu/internships/troubleshooting.html April 19, 2010

Self-Reflection Exercise

Objectives:
- Students understand that self-reflection and journal writing can help to enhance an internship experience.
- Select and/or create journal questions that would help them reflect most effectively on an internship experience.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handout: **"Internship Journal,"** pens/pencils, paper

Ask students what self-reflection is. Explain that it is the process of learning about and examining one's thoughts and feelings; self-observation; the act of looking within oneself.

Explain to students that you are going to ask them to participate in a reflection activity.

Gratitude

Much of our time is spent complaining about the things we don't like, the things that are not going right. Take this time to think about all of the things that are going well, the things you have to be thankful for. Take out a piece of paper and write **"My Life"** at the top of it. Think about the **positive** things you have in your life — think about your health, relationships, education/training, workplace, community, etc., and write a bulleted list on the paper. Every time you feel a negative thought creep in, attempt to trump it with a greater positive thought. Continue listing items until you are asked to stop.
Adapted from **http://www.ehow.com/way_5173463_self_reflection-activities.html** April 20, 2010

Give students three minutes to work on their list. Ask them how they feel thinking about all of the positive things in their lives — all of the things they have to be thankful for.

Ask students what they think the benefits of self-reflection are for an intern. Ask them if any of them keep a journal or have ever kept a journal. Why do people write in journals? Journals are a great way to self-reflect, and it is a great way for interns to make the most out of their internship experience.

Hand out **"Internship Journal."** Ask for one (or more) volunteer(s) to read the top paragraphs. Ask if there are any questions or comments about what was just read. Allow students to read the journal questions silently. If students need help reading, read the questions out loud or pair students up. Ask students to choose 8 questions (from the list or create their own) that they feel would be most helpful in reflecting on an internship experience. Once they have picked their top 8 questions, have them pair up and explain why they chose the questions they chose. Ask students who created new questions to share the questions with the larger group. Journals are a great way to reflect on many different experiences.

What is an Internship?

"***Definition:*** Internships provide real world experience to those looking to explore or gain the relevant knowledge and skills required to enter into a particular career field. Internships are relatively short term in nature with the primary focus on getting some on the job training and taking what's learned in the classroom and applying it to the real world. Interns generally have a supervisor who assigns specific tasks and evaluates the intern's overall work. For internships for credit, usually a faculty sponsor will work along with the site supervisor to ensure that the necessary learning is taking place. Interns can be high school or college students or even adults interested in trying out a new career. Many college students do internships to gain relevant experience in a particular career field as well as to get exposure to determine if they have a genuine interest in the field. Internships are an excellent way to begin building those all important connections that are invaluable in developing and maintaining a strong professional network for the future."

Penny Loretto

http://internships.about.com/od/internshipsquestions/g/internshipdefin.htm

- An internship is your best chance to test out potential career choices. You'll get real-life experience doing the work of an employee in an organization.
- An internship is also a good way to learn about different management styles and work environments. Internships help you learn what type of work suits you.
- An internship helps you develop professional skills and build a network of contacts. This will help you later when you begin your job search.
- An internship is the best way to connect the learning you are doing in the classroom to the world of work. Basically, you'll learn by doing.
- An internship will help you get a job after you graduate. Employers seek job candidates with some type of experience. Internships build your resume and increase your chances of getting hired later.

http://www.clacareer.umn.edu/internships/index.html

Internship Journal

The journal provides an opportunity for you to write about your learning experience. There are several ways that you can use your journal to examine your internship experience. Some of its uses are to examine new knowledge and skills, to discover what you feel as a result of experiences in your internship, and to reflect on your own learning. In your journal you can reflect on successes or problems, as well as anxieties or other feelings you have about your internship. You may record your responses to difficulties that come up during the course of your internship. In addition, you may record personal reactions to internship coordinators, supervisors, co-workers or other people you meet through the internship. You may use the journal to record any problems you are having that interfere with your learning experience.

You may write about anything that relates to your experience at the internship or about experiences outside of the internship that relate to the "you" participating in the internship. If you choose, you may use any of the ideas listed below as starting points for your journal entry. You may wish to use them once, or to repeat the topic if it seems useful or important. You may be asked to share some of your reflections if your internship is connected to an education opportunity. Consider the journal an opportunity to remind yourself of situations on which you would like some input.

This journal is specifically designed to help you process the learning that happens as a result of your internship.
Adapted from http://www.nww.org/qwbl/tools/kcktoolkit/Print_Toolkit.PDF April 6, 2010

Possible Internship Journal Questions

Starting your Internship

1. Describe your job — what a typical day looks like, your regular responsibilities, what special projects you work on, the job expectations, etc.
2. What was the orientation process like? What training did you get for your position? Did it prepare you for your internship? What else do you wish you had been told/taught from the beginning?

Reflecting on your Internship

3. Explain three new things you have learned through your internship
4. Describe the best thing that happened at work this week — something you were really proud of yourself for or something that was exciting or new.
5. What skills/personal qualities are most useful and most important at your job?
6. What do you like best about your job? What do you like least about your job? What parts of you job do you think you do best? What parts are most challenging?

Things I am learning about myself

7. Are you interested in continuing to work in this field? Why or why not?
8. What have you learned about yourself through this experience?
9. What are you most proud of — what have you accomplished? What does this mean to you?
10. What are some of the unexpected challenges you have faced? What are some of the frustrations? How have you dealt with these challenges? Who has helped you?

Other things to consider

11. How have you dealt with conflict at work? With whom have you had conflicts?
12. What really good decisions have you made at work or about work? What helped you make those decisions?
13. How important are communication skills at your internship? Describe an experience where communication went really well — and describe an example of a miscommunication. What were the differences in these experiences?
14. Create a top ten list of things other young people need to know before they begin an internship.